

INVESTMENT BANKING GROUP

2026 Admit FAQ & Summer Prep Suggestions

Future Booth IBGers,

The following guide answers questions pooled from admitted students regarding the investment banking recruiting process and provides summer preparation guidance to those who wish to hit the ground running this fall quarter. **If you are an incoming Booth student this fall and interested in investment banking, please review this FAQ in its entirety.**

This summer, the IBG co-chairs and other IBG members will be extremely busy working at their summer internships. As a result, **incoming 2Y IBG members will not be able to answer any questions until we have returned from the summer for your orientation in September.** Please use this guide and the resources provided by Career Services to prepare for your transition to Booth this summer. We have split this guide into two parts. The first part goes over the absolutely essential questions and guidance for the summer. The second part answers other miscellaneous questions.

****Important:** Do not start networking with bankers before recruiting begins in the fall. Absolutely do not add bankers on LinkedIn, cold message them, etc. This could negatively impact your IB recruiting process. You will have the time and framework to network once recruiting starts.

We look forward to welcoming you to campus!

Best,
Your 2026-27 Cochairs

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PART I: ESSENTIAL QUESTIONS

1. Can you provide a high level overview of the NYC recruiting process?

Please refer to the Canvas course on Investment Banking that will be provided by Career Services. A very high-level overview of the process is as follows:

Recruiting Timeline

Key Dates – New York

Summer - Orientation	Early Oct - Mid Oct	Mid Oct - Late Oct	Late Oct - Mid Dec	Mid Dec	Dec - Jan
Preparation	Pre-Recruiting	Campus Recruiting	Invite Only Recruiting	Bank Week (NY Trek)	Interviews & Managing Offers
❖ Update your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Prepare attire & WFH setup ❖ Explore region, product / coverage groups ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Refine your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Network with second years ❖ Decide region, product / coverage groups ❖ Prepare informational call questions ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Information Sessions ❖ Meet-and-Greets with bankers ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Banks host "Invite Only" events ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Mix of open and closed events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Submit all applications by listed deadlines ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical) ❖ Interviews (first week of Jan) ❖ Sell events and conversations

2. I am interested in recruiting for a region that is not NYC (i.e., Chicago, West Coast, Houston).

What are the recruiting timelines of these regions?

Regional recruiting timelines are earlier relative to NYC and can be an intense, but shorter, process.

Candidates interested in recruiting regionally should *strongly* consider summer preparation. Please note that **for Houston, the process will begin before Booth's on-campus banking recruiting so students should prepare in summer and complete the IBG survey in Slack to indicate intention of recruiting for Houston.** The timelines for Chicago, West Coast and Houston are as follows:

Chicago Timeline:

Recruiting Timeline

Key Dates – **Chicago**

Summer - Orientation	Early Oct - Mid Oct	Mid Oct - Late Oct	Late Oct - Mid Nov	Late Nov - Dec
Preparation	Pre-Recruiting	Campus Recruiting	Invite Only Recruiting & Office Visits	Interviews & Managing Offers
❖ Update your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Prepare attire & WFH setup ❖ Explore region, product / coverage groups ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Refine your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Network with second years ❖ Decide region, product / coverage groups ❖ Prepare informational call questions ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Information Sessions ❖ Meet-and-Greets with bankers ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Banks host "Invite Only" events ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Submit all applications by listed deadlines ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical) ❖ Interviews (Nov 30 first rounds; superdays to follow) ❖ Sell events and conversations

West Coast Timeline:

Recruiting Timeline

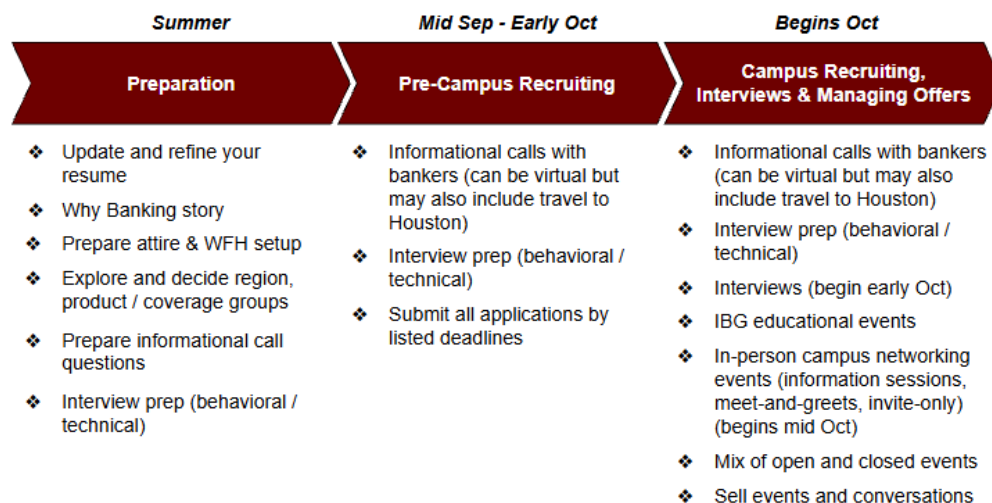
Key Dates – **West Coast**

Summer - Orientation	Early Oct - Mid Oct	Mid Oct - Late Oct	Late Oct - Mid Nov	Early Nov	Late Nov - Dec
Preparation	Pre-Recruiting	Campus Recruiting	Invite Only Recruiting	West Coast Trek	Interviews & Managing Offers
❖ Update your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Prepare attire & WFH setup ❖ Explore region, product / coverage groups ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Refine your resume ❖ Why Banking story ❖ Network with second years ❖ Decide region, product / coverage groups ❖ Prepare informational call questions ❖ Foundational technical prep	❖ Information Sessions ❖ Meet-and-Greets with bankers ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Banks host "Invite Only" events ❖ Informational calls with bankers ❖ IBG educational events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Mix of open and closed events ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical)	❖ Submit all applications by listed deadlines ❖ Interview prep (behavioral / technical) ❖ Interviews (first rounds week before Thanksgiving; superdays week after Thanksgiving) ❖ Sell events and conversations

Houston Timeline:

Recruiting Timeline

Key Dates – *Houston*



Other domestic locations may hire through Booth's campus process or independently on the Booth timeline or a different timeline. Typically, these are most similar to the Chicago timeline.

Activity for international locations varies year to year depending on business needs but has been more limited in the last few years. The London timeline typically aligns with NY and the Hong Kong timeline can be earlier or later than NY.

3. What can I do to prepare this summer for the behavioral components of the investment banking recruiting process?

There are two priorities when it comes to preparing for the behavioral components of recruiting prior to coming to campus. The first is preparing your resume. Career Services will provide a Booth template and extensive resources on [Canvas](#) for how to prepare your resume. In the fall, you will then meet with IBG representatives and Career Services to refine the draft you prepared prior to coming to campus. Please utilize the resume resources from Career Services and **take this summer material seriously**. The more effort you put into perfecting your resume prior to getting to campus, the more effort you can spend preparing for other aspects of recruiting when you get to campus.

The second priority is to start formulating your "Tell me about yourself"/"Why Banking" pitch. Your answer to the "Tell me about yourself" question in coffee chats and interviews is **the most important**

part of the IB recruiting process. Basic and/or impersonal answers are the number one reason candidates are cut from a given bank's recruiting process. **It is highly advisable to spend time over the summer reflecting deeply on why you want to pursue banking** and how your previous experiences inform your decision to pivot. The most successful stories are *logical* and *authentic*.

To help prepare for this aspect of the process, you should begin formulating a 1-2 minute pitch that goes through your background highlighting the following:

1. Personal background- Name, where you are from, education, and what you studied.
2. Professional background- Former employer, your role/impact, and why you switched roles if applicable. This should be in chronological order (job #1, impact/role #1, transitional reason #1, job #2, impact/role #2, etc.).
3. Why banking- How your professional experiences made you interested in deals and want to pursue a career in investment banking.
4. Why Booth- Why you chose to get an MBA given your answers in (2) and (3).
5. What you are looking for going forward- If applicable for specific location/group.

Your pitch will be refined by IBG members once you get to campus this fall. Preparing and refining the pitch over the summer ensures IBG members can help you perfect it once you begin speaking with full-time bankers.

If you are unsure of where to start, the following resources from Career Services will help you begin:

- Complete the [Self-Assessment assignments in Canvas](#)
- Complete the [Develop Your Career Focus assignment](#) in Canvas, using the Exploring Careers page content (choose the investment banking job description)
- Complete the [Networking & Story assignment](#) in Canvas.

4. I have heard there are technical questions asked in IB interviews. How can I prepare for these questions?

Technical questions regarding accounting, valuation, and market knowledge are indeed asked in interviews and coffee chats by bankers. It is important to note, however, that the behavioral components are the most important parts to prepare for over the summer. Technical questions testing your knowledge of accounting and valuation principles are often not asked until later in the process in the respective recruiting region and if a candidate does not master the behavioral components, they will never be asked a technical question in the first place. That being said, **it is a good idea to familiarize yourself with these topics prior to getting to campus.** We recommend the following materials.

For general knowledge on the markets:

- Wall Street Journal
- Financial Times
- Bloomberg Live- you can access this for free and watch the live feed via [youtube](#)

For knowledge on specific industries/topics:

- It is impossible to provide an exhaustive list for each industry, so we recommend a quick google for your desired industry/product group.

For finance fundamentals:

- [Breaking Into Wall Street 400 Questions Guide](#)- This is a free guide available online by Mergers & Inquisitions that goes through standard and fairly easy technical questions asked in interviews.
- [Wall Street Prep "Redbook"](#)- This is an additional interview guide that goes through various technical interview topics more thoroughly.
- [OfferGoblin](#) - Flashcard style learning with questions pulled directly from banks. It is a good way to test your knowledge and diagnose which areas you are weaker in. There are a handful of similar resources you can Google, but OfferGoblin was started by a Boothie. Similar to the 400 questions guide, I would avoid relying on memorization and instead focus on learning the underlying concepts.

Books for those who are interested:

- *Investment Banking: Valuation, Leveraged Buyouts, and Mergers and Acquisitions* by Rosenbaum and Pearl- This is an **in-depth** overview of the 3 valuation methods and M&A.
- *Financial Modeling and Valuation: A Practical Guide to Investment Banking and Private Equity* by Pignataro- This is a great learning tool for **beginners**. It teaches basic accounting principles and walks you through building an actual DCF for Amazon.

Resources from Career Services:

- Wall Street Prep- You can set up a free Wall Street Prep account through Booth [here](#) once admits are granted access in June.

5. What is the difference between product and coverage groups? How should I decide which groups I should target during recruiting?

Coverage groups specialize in a specific industry niche, such as Technology, Media & Telecom (TMT), Healthcare, Industrials, Financial Institutions (FIG), Consumer/Retail, or Energy. They act as the "owner" of the client relationship. Their goal is to understand industry trends, cultivate long-term relationships with clients, and advise on any deal type within their sector.

Product groups specialize in a specific type of financial transaction across all industries. Common product groups include Mergers & Acquisitions (M&A), Equity Capital Markets (ECM), Debt Capital Markets (DCM), Leveraged Finance (LevFin), and Restructuring (RX).

Your choice of groups will be dictated by two main components:

- Geographic interest- New York will have the broadest set of opportunities. If, however, you are interested in recruiting regionally, generally speaking you should target the following groups in each given geography:
 - Chicago- Industrials, Middle-market banks HQ'd in Chicago tend to have groups in addition to an industrials team
 - West Coast Tech and Healthcare
 - Houston- Energy (Oil and Gas, some Renewables)
- Your professional background and personal interest- If you have a professional background in a particular industry, it will be an easier pivot to recruit for an IB group that is relevant to that

industry. For instance, if you previously worked at or consulted for an automotive company, industrials would be an easy sell. You can still recruit for groups in which you do not have work experience, however, you will need to be able to speak to your interest/passion through demonstrated knowledge and research of that industry/product.

Plan to narrow your focus to 1 - 3 product/coverage groups and 1 target geography.

6. What is the difference between bulge bracket, middle market, and boutique investment banks?

Bulge bracket banks are the largest global banks that provide full-service banking capabilities. This means they provide advisory (M&A) services and financing solutions (IPOs and debt lending). They utilize their massive balance sheets to lend money to clients, which helps them win mandates. Examples are Morgan Stanley, J.P. Morgan, and Bank of America.

Boutique banks provide exclusively advisory services (typically M&A and/or restructuring). They pride themselves on winning business off the quality of their ideas and relationships. They typically do not have large balance sheets that allow them to lend. Examples are Evercore, Lazard, and Moelis.

Middle market banks provide advisory services to smaller businesses with a deal range typically between \$50 and \$500 million (although this can vary substantially). They often work extensively with private equity firms to work on sell-side mandates and typically do not do too much buy-side work. Examples are Harris Williams, Baird, and Lincoln International.

7. How important are pre-MBA IB recruiting opportunities? What about pre-MBA internships?

We do not recommend admits engage with pre-MBA IB recruiting opportunities. Pre-MBA IB recruiting opportunities and internships are absolutely *not* required or important to be successful in the recruiting process this fall. The IB recruiting process is a very personalized journey in which you will cultivate many relationships this fall quarter. **If you choose to pursue pre-MBA IB opportunities, you are doing so at your own risk as representing yourself in an unprepared or unprofessional manner presents future reputational risk that could follow you to on-campus recruiting.** The IB world is very close and bankers (particularly those from the same MBA program) speak with one another about candidates. Note that Career Services has information about [engaging with pre-MBA recruiting opportunities](#).

8. Should we purchase suits/ties/shoes before arriving to save time/bandwidth on these small logistical things? What is the expected attire? Will I be in a suit most days in the fall?

Purchasing attire prior to arriving on campus is a good idea in order to save time and bandwidth on these logistics. Below you will find guidance for what is expected. It is expected as IBG members that you will be in this professional attire everyday in the fall. The key to this professional attire is conformity. **You do not want to stand out for the wrong reasons (e.g. your attire)**, so ensure your professional attire is conservative and follows our guidelines, which match the industry's expectations.

IB recruiting requires **business professional** attire. Both men and women are required to wear a suit jacket every day.

- Suit (err on the conservative side) – Men: navy or charcoal grey only, no black allowed (2 total suits are sufficient); Women: black or navy suit jacket with matching skirt, pants, or dress. No patterns allowed on suit jackets. Any dresses or skirts must extend beyond your fingertips when holding your arms straight down.
- Shirt/Top – Women: neutral (white, cream, etc) or dark colored dress shirt, modest, if any, patterns; Men: button up shirt, solid colored (white or light blue only)
- Shoes – Men: black shoes and belt (do not wear brown; black is the Wall Street standard); Women: typically neutral colors, flats or heels are fine
- Ties – Men: Solid, conservative colors only (no patterns are acceptable)
- Make sure you are comfortable standing for long periods of time
- Accessories (err on conservative side) – modest jewelry, fragrances (if any). Do not wear watches
- Small purses are typically discouraged for these events, use jacket pocket to carry essentials; you will need your hands free during networking conversations
- Other – Modest make-up and clean shaven recommended

PART II: MISCELLANEOUS QUESTIONS

9. What does the preparation process with IBG look like once we're on campus?

The on-campus preparation begins with finalizing resumes and your stories (why banking, why a region, why a particular bank, why a particular group, etc). You will be meeting with the IBG co-chairs, Career Services, and having mock coffee chats with 2Ys to ensure you are ready to talk to a full-time banker. Throughout the process, you will continue to sharpen these stories as you learn specific information about banks and groups. The next progression is technical preparation. For this, IBG will provide group educational opportunities on the major topics, but there will be a big emphasis on self-study and studying with peers for technicals. Closer to your interview timeline based on region, we will have mock interviews to put everything together and ensure you are ready, **but do not leave technical preparation until the last minute - there is a lot to learn, and poor performance on technical questions can prevent an offer from being extended.**

10. Is recruiting for IB in Chicago feasible for Internationals? (Or would you recommend NYC or CA instead).

International students can absolutely recruit for Chicago (or other regions outside of NYC) but should understand the tradeoffs to pursuing this path. Compared to NYC, there are typically fewer banks that sponsor in Chicago as many of the opportunities in Chicago come from middle market banks that traditionally have not sponsored in the past. On top of this, any student recruiting for Chicago (or other regions outside of NYC) must convince bankers that they really want to be in that region. The reasoning for recruiting in Chicago must be something beyond "This is where I go to business school". For instance, do you have friends or family in Chicago? Have you ever lived in the Midwest? That said, if an international student has an industry background that is covered in a regional market, and they intend to focus on that coverage group, regional recruiting could be a good strategy. For example, an international student with oil & gas experience might do well recruiting in Houston.

11. Is there a list of the banks that came to campus to recruit for summer associates last year?

This list is not exhaustive as some firms did not have information sessions but still recruited Boothies, but see the following: Barclays, BofA, Centerview, Citi, Evercore, Goldman, Greenhill, Guggenheim, Harris Williams, Houlihan Lokey, Jefferies, JPM, Lazard, Lincoln, Marathon Capital, Moelis, MS, PJT, Piper Sandler, PWP, Rothschild, Santander, Truist, Wells Fargo.

12. Should we expect AI-related questions during our recruitment process? Do you recommend we begin learning how to use tools such as Claude?

Banks will not ask if you can use AI tools. We would personally recommend being familiar with AI tools as they are a huge time saver.

Non-exhaustive examples of AI use (Claude, ChatGPT, Gemini, etc.):

- Using AI to research deals and brainstorm rationale (always fact check using CapIQ and/or Press Releases)
- Using AI to discuss trends in your desired space
- Importing the 400 Question Guide or other guides to quiz on technicals

13. Any insight on how you decided IB during the pre MBA summer over other potential post MBA avenues ?

It depends on your interests (work, worklife balance, compensation, progression, etc.). Career Services will have guides on Canvas on selecting a career and if you are undecided, you should really take advantage of these resources. IB is not for everyone and recruiting for IB requires a *massive* time commitment. Please see the Career Services links in question 3 for information on self-assessment.

14. I overheard that there is a guy who comes on campus and custom makes suits for Booth students. Is this true, and if so: 1) when does he arrive and 2) do you know the pricing details?

Last year, this was run outside of IBG through a partnership a 2Y had with a tailor. There was a package that came with 2 suits, 2 shirts, and 2 ties for \$1,119. He came late September to early October, so timing-wise we would not depend on this service and would instead purchase your items before coming to campus if possible.

15. Will we learn/need to learn Excel during recruiting, or should we postpone that until after we (hopefully) have an offer?

You will likely not be asked to work in Excel during recruiting. Some groups may have modelling tests, however, this is rare.

16. Will there be a spreadsheet explaining how each bank is unique? For example, maybe at Bank A they have a specific team for M&A, but at Bank B they have less deal flow and each coverage group is responsible for M&A in their sector, etc. Would be a nice reference for everyone.

We do not have an official guide as banks are very fluid given the turnover of personnel. Question #5 discusses broad differences between bulge bracket, boutique, and middle market banks. For bank specific information such as the types of deals they work on and the culture, you will learn this through the information sessions and coffee chats.

17. How do students decide what city they want to recruit for?

Deciding which city to recruit for comes down to your personal preferences as well as where your strategy and candidacy will be strongest. The two key factors are your connections to a region and your industry background. For your personal ties to a region, this matters significantly for regional recruiting (i.e., Chicago, West Coast, Houston, etc.), however, it is not as significant for NY recruiting. The personal ties can include being from the region, having lived there, or having family and friends there. This adds an additional personal layer to your candidacy and helps you connect with the bankers in that region.

The second layer is your professional background. Certain regions are dominated by specific coverage groups: Chicago skews toward Industrials, West Coast toward Tech and Healthcare, and Houston toward Energy. If your professional background aligns naturally with the groups concentrated in a particular

region, that can be a compelling reason to recruit there even if your personal ties to that city are limited. A strong industry fit gives you a credible, authentic story for why you are targeting that market

If you do not have a strong industry fit for the groups in a given regional market *and* you lack meaningful ties to that region, then NYC is almost certainly your best path. New York offers the broadest set of opportunities across all product and coverage groups, and it does not require the same level of geographic justification that regional recruiting demands.

18. Will resume review occur before applications are due/submitted?

Yes. Resumes should be final before banks come on campus early October. Before coming on campus, your resume should be in the Booth template and in a strong place, so that last minute edits are minimal. Resumes will be reviewed by the IBG co-chairs, Career Services, and other 2Ys.

19. How do students know what industries banks are recruiting for (ie/ industrials group, healthcare group, etc.)?

Unfortunately banks change their summer associate program every year. They will give exact guidance on which groups/geographies they are recruiting for during the information session.

20. How have people that have been interested in PE and IB recruiting balanced IB recruiting and getting an internship within the PE/VC Lab?

It is not advisable to recruit for PE/VC and IB at the same time. Applications for the PE/VC lab are due in early October and some students network and interview in the fall before PE/VC lab internships start in January. Your number one priority in the Fall should be IB if you want to maximize your chances of getting a summer internship. Also avoid telling banks that you are looking forward to the PE/VC lab as they can take it as a sign that you are not fully interested in IB. Traditionally, students do the PE/VC lab in their second year so that they can focus on IB recruiting as a 1Y.

21. Other than having stories for each desk (why M&A vs tech vs industrials vs...), what would you recommend as your long-term goal if asked? Definitely say career banker vs hoping to one day leave for corp dev?

This is unique to each person, but our experience is that banks want to know that you are interested in a long-term banking career. If you say this is just a stepping stone for you, it likely will not reflect well in your relationship with the bank.

22. When are we doing our geography treks (NYC, SF, Houston, etc.)?

Booth has a formal trek week in mid-December when the NY banking trek typically takes place. Regional treks depend on student interest and firm availability, but could be in late October or early November.

23. How much flexibility is there in scheduling Zoom calls (for example, if you have to attend a wedding during recruiting season and you know the date months in advance)?

This will depend on your communication with the banker you are assigned to chat with. We would avoid offering a time if you are going to be at a wedding. Also some chats happen on weekends, but ~90% will happen during the week. Do not offer a weekend option unless the banker tells you they are open to

connecting over the weekend. Finally, note that most coffee chats are conducted via Zoom with the following exceptions: If you are recruiting in Chicago or if you do chats while on treks.

24. Do I need to have a professional headshot before coming on campus?

If you are able to complete this easily over the summer, then we would recommend you do. The headshot should be in professional attire and focused on you. Please see the link to our [IBG website](#) for our examples. If you are unable to obtain a headshot, our student group Photo Booth will be offering a headshot service during orientation. They have not finalized rates, but it should be around \$40.